The Burn Journals

By Brent Runyon

When we moved here, the first thing they did was start testing me to see how smart I was. I didn't even have time to make any friends before they put me in this program for smart kids called GT, which stands for Gifted and Talented. I started calling it Goobers and Twerps because all of the kids that were in it were real dorks. None of the cool kids were in it. None. Well, one, if you count me. I started begging my parents to let me out of the program because it was so stupid. I kept begging and begging, and then, finally, this year, they let me out of GT, and for some reason I started doing really badly. Now I'm getting F's in a couple of classes.

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INTRODUCTION

One February day in 1991, Runyon came home from eighth grade, had a snack, soaked his full-length bathrobe in gasoline, and set himself on fire. He intended to kill himself. But Brent was not successful . . . instead he survived to suffer the pain of burns to 85 percent of his body. What made a smart, popular, funny, loving boy try to take his own life? Depression, a chemical imbalance? I don't have the answers and neither does Brent Runyon, but the following excerpts from The Burn Journals tries to explain what happened before, during and after the horrendous "accident."

I'm awake, listening to the radio, and Mom is yelling at me to get out of bed. I don't want to get out of bed. I don't want to go to school. Maybe I should play sick, but I've done that too many times this year already.

I run the whole thing back in my head. I did so many things wrong, I can't even believe it. I shouldn't have taken the matches from Adam. I shouldn't have set the whole pack on fire. I shouldn't have thrown them into that locker. And I really shouldn't have put that lock on the locker.

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When I walk into gym, Mr. Huff is standing in the back of the locker room, right next to the locker that was on fire. He says, "Okay, boys, settle down. Some arsonist among you purposefully set a shirt on fire. Boys, whoever did this is in an enormous amount of trouble. Charges will be pressed. He'll be expelled. So whoever did it, or if you know who did it, come see me in my office before the end of the period." His eyes lock with mine on the last word and I feel a cold sickness all over my body, but somehow I manage to keep my eyes from showing that I know he knows it's me.

What am I going to do? What am I going to do? . . . I'm going to kill myself.

I think about that movie we saw in English class, about the guy who's standing on the bridge waiting to get hung. As soon as the rope snaps his head back, he's dead.

I wonder why all the ways I've tried to kill myself haven't worked. I mean, I've tried hanging. I used to have a noose tied to my closet pole. I'd go in there and slip the thing over my head and let my weight

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go. But every time I started to lose consciousness, I'd just stand up.

I tried to take pills. One afternoon, I took twenty Advil, but that just made me sleepy.

And all the times I tried to cut my wrists, I could never cut deep enough. I took my knife from its hiding place between the mattress and the box spring and held it against my wrist. I sliced as fast as I could and bit my lip from the pain. I hung my arm between the two twin beds pushed together from when my brother used to share the room with me and let it bleed. I was surprised when I work up in the morning. I had to find a Band-Aid big enough to cover the wound and told my parents I'd scratched my wrist on a locker.

That's the thing – your body tries to keep you alive no matter what you do. I've got to think of a way to kill myself that I can't turn back from.

When seventh period is finally over, I run to my locker and put all my books inside. I won't need them anymore. Laura walks with me down D hall. She says, "Hey, I heard you set that fire in gym class."

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"Yeah."

"What are you going to do?"

"I'm going to set myself on fire." She stops at her locker and I keep walking.

On the bus ride home, I sit by myself. I lean my head against the cold glass window and try not to think about all the stupid things I've done, all the bad things I've done, and all the pain I've caused everyone.

My brother is playing basketball outside the house when I get home. I rebound the ball for him and throw it back. I tell him the whole story, about what I did and what they're going to do to me. I don't tell him what I'm going to do to myself.

When I'm done talking, he says, "That sucks," and I go inside the house. I don't have to write a note anymore. Craig knows everything.

I walk out to the shed to get the gas can. I bring it inside to the bathroom at the top of the stairs because that's the room with the most locks. I go back downstairs and get the matches from the kitchen.

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I take off all my clothes and put on the pair of red boxers that my mom bought for me at the mall last weekend. I bring my bathrobe into the shower and I pour the gasoline all over it. The gas can is only about a quarter full, but it seems like enough.

I step into the bathtub and I put the bathrobe over my shoulders. It's wet and heavy, but there's something kind of comforting about the smell, like going on a long car trip. I hold the box of matches out in front of me in my left hand.

I take out a strike-anywhere match and hold it against the box.

Should I do it? . . . Yes. Do it.

I strike the match, but it doesn't light. Try again.

I light the match. Nothing happens. I bring it closer to my wrist and then it goes up, all over me, eating through me everywhere. I can't breathe. I'm screaming, "Craig! Craig!"

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I fall down. I'm going to die. I'm going to find out what death is like. I'm going to know. But nothing's happening.

This hurts too much. I need to stop it. I need to get up. I stand. I don't know how I stand, but I do, and I turn on the shower. I'm breathing water and smoke. I unlock the door and open it. My hand is all black. I walk out. There's Craig with Rusty, or dog, next to him. They have the same expression on their faces.

Craig yells something and runs downstairs. I think he's calling 911. I'm following him. He hands me the phone and runs off. There's a woman on the phone asking me questions. I try to tell her what's happened, but my voice sounds choked and brittle. There's something wrong with my voice.

The woman on the phone says the fire trucks and ambulances are on their way. Somehow she knows my address. Craig is gone now, gone to get Mom, and Rusty is hiding somewhere. Smoke is coming from the bathroom upstairs and I can see that the whole room has turned black. I look down and see my flesh is

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charred and flaking and the boxer shorts are burnt into my skin

The woman on the phone says everything is going to be all right, and I believe her. She keeps asking me if I'm still on fire and I say, "I don't think so."

I'm walking around the kitchen, waiting for the ambulance to come. I can see my reflection in the microwave. Where's my hair? Where did my hair go? Is that my face?

We used to put marshmallows in the microwave. We used to watch them get bigger and bigger and then shrink down . "Oh god, just tell them to get here, just tell them to get here, okay? I'm so sorry. I'm so sorry."

I can hear the sirens in the distance now . . . Then the firemen are here. They're putting me on a plastic sheet. They say I'm going to be okay. One of them puts something over my face. That feels good. That feels so good. The cold air feels so good going into my lungs

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What are they talking about? What are they saying? They're giving me a shot They say it's going to make the pain go away. Make the pain go away. Make the pain go away.

I'm looking at the faces of all the men who are gathered around me. Their eyes are so blue and so clear.

I turn my head and see Craig in the front hall. He's yelling and punching the walls. He's angry

And my mom is here, and she's smiling and saying she loves me, and her eyes, which are green like my eyes, are the most beautiful things I've ever seen.

I don't want to die anymore. I hope Craig can love me again.

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I've been [at the burn center] for exactly one month.

Mom sits by my bedside and I can tell that she wants to talk about the fire and everything about it. So I start by trying to say why I was so sad, and how I thought that the principal was going to expel me and how

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I didn't want them to be mad at me because they both wanted me to be so smart and I'm sorry I couldn't be what you wanted. And she says, "You are everything we wanted." And we both cry together.

"Mom, no one's ever going to love me, are they?"

But mom puts her hand on my fingertips and whispers, "Brent, listen to me, honey, you are so smart and so kind. You will fall in love, and someone will fall in love with you. I promise."

It makes me feel better to hear her say that, but I can tell that she's not really sure. It'll be okay, I tell myself, I can live in the basement when I get older so people don't have to look at me. I'm crying and crying. I want her to go away and leave me alone.

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People here like to talk to me about Pain Management. They ask me to rate my pain on a scale of one to ten. One being the least painful and ten being the most. I don't think they have a number for some of

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the pain I'm going through. I don't think they even have a number.

I keep thinking about it. I was in the bathroom and I had the gas can and the matches and I sat on the toilet. That's when I should've realized how stupid I was being. That's when I should've stopped it.

But I stood in the bathroom and put the bathrobe on, and it was wet and heavy, and I could have taken it off and gone back outside to play basketball with Carig and said, You won't believe what I almost did. And he would've known what to do. He would've gotten me help and made that Mom and Dad weren't made at me. I should've done that.

I wish, I wish, I wish, I wish, I wish I'd stopped. But I didn't.

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Mom is here and she looks like she's ready to talk. If I just say it, then maybe I'll be able to stop feeling so bad inside. I'll say, Hey Mom, guess who tried to kill themselves a bunch of other times besides the

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one you know about? That's right, me. Hey, Mom, remember the Band-Aids on my wrist? Well, I didn't really scrape it on my locker. I cut it with a knife that I kept under my bed. . . . And you know the furnace in the basement, I thought about pouring gasoline in there and blowing up the whole house . . . And you know how I got the book on how to make knots? It was so I could tie a noose and hang myself from the closet pole.

I can't say any of this. So I say, "Mom . . . when I . . . . when I tried . . . to hurt myself before . . . that wasn't the first time that I tried to do something like that."

She doesn't look surprised, but she's starting to cry. She puts her hand on top of mine. I know, honey. I figured it wasn't the first time. I'm sorry I didn't know you were so sad." She's crying hard now, and I'm crying too.

"I know. I'm sorry, Mom."

"Brenny?" she says. "About a week before your accident . . . .

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An accidental house fire. Right. Okay. Okay. We can say that. We don't have to tell anyone what really happened. An accidental house fire.

". . . . we got into a fright at the dinner table and you stormed up to your room, and I remember, I said, "Where are you going?" and you said, I think I heard you say, "I'm going to set myself on fire."

I think about it. "I don't think I said that. I mean, I might have, but I didn't mean it."

She can hardly get the words out, she's crying so hard. "But if you ever get that sad again, you have to promise to tell someone so they can help you . . . And know that we love you so much and we don't ever want to lose you."

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It's been nine months and I still don't know why I did it. I was so sad. I wanted to be funny and cool and I wanted everyone to love me, but I still don't know why I did it. [Once I was home] we never mentioned my

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suicide attempt or my time in the hospital – my parents still call it an accident. To them, the entire thing was a mystery they'd given up on solving.

But as I talked to more people, I realized that the only thing unique about my story is the rather unfortunate and dramatic way in which I tried to kill myself. Other than that, I'm just another guy with a history of depression, which is somehow very comforting to me . . .

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Brent Runyon
ISBN: 978-1400096428
Publisher: Vintage
Date (Month/Year): Oct 2005

AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier

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